Being Latino – A Program

By Carlos Andres Gomez and Jonathan Mendoza

CHANGE OF CHARACTER VOICE AND STANCE RECOMMENDED FOR EACH POEM

Where are You Really From?
by Carlos Andres Gomez

(Pg 81-82) The man's words to me are not offered

but flung:

"So, what are you? I mean, where are you from?"

I say, "New York."

"But your name is Carlos -- where are you ***really*** from?"

I say, "New York."

"Bueno, yo soy Latino - mi padre es Colombiano, mi madre es Estadounidense, nací in New York City, *["Well, I'm Latino. My father is Colombian. My mother is American. I was born in New York City."]* I lived in 4 countries, moved 12 times, and went to 12 schools before I graduated high school

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– is not what I would ever say in 12,341 years

because I don't owe a damn thing to anyone.

What ***am*** I?

INTRODUCTION

What does it mean to be Latino? To be Hispanic? What does it mean to be American? Identity, or how we understand and express ourselves, is very complex. The US Latino community is incredibly diverse, and many of us have layered identities.

*As activist Jonathan Jayes Green has said "I am not willing to compartmentalize my identities. I am all that I am all the time." * Latino/Hispanic identities are unique and shaped by factors such as geography – over 20 countries -- heritage, race, and more. This program explores the struggle to be both Latino and American.*

Where are You Really From? by Carlos Andres Gomez and Onomastico by Jonathan Mendoza and What's Genocide? by Carlos Andres Gomez

TIONAL USE O

What ***am*** I?

Dude discovers his first Latino with green eyes

and suddenly appoints himself the authority on Latinidad.

"But you totally don't look Mexican . . .

Oh, Colombian. But like what percentage are you . . .?

"Do you speak it, though? Fluently?

Dance salsa? Well? Oh, but not ***both*** parents."

I know: everyone you hang out with looks like you.
Has a name you are able to pronounce and/or
sounds pulled directly from an episode of *Leave it to Beaver*.

Here's the deal: Latin America is not just Mexico (actually pronounced ***Méjico, pero*** whatever). Central America is not part of South America. And Mexican is still not a language.

The question, "Where are you from?" -- in our current America -- is a slur disguised with a question mark,
a passive-aggressive microaggression saying:
"You are **'other'**."
Saying: "You are **not,** nor will ever **be,** one of us."
Saying: "Go back to where you came from!"

But I am from a place beyond place. A place beyond your linear and limited concept of time.

I am from bloodlines unkillable as water.

I am a boy without a word of English in his mouth
in a Catholic school classroom in south Florida, his son
on a stage on the Lower East Side tonight

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reading this poem for him.

I am what hard-earned joy looks like
carved from the wreckage of a lifetime's worth of grief.

You are not ready for the answers to the questions you ask, not ready for the worlds these words might shake free. You could never understand what I ***am***, or where ***I*** am ***from***.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Carlos Andres Gomez
Book: Fight Evil with Poetry – Anthology Volume 1, Pg 81-82
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Date (Month/Year): October 2018

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier – MS (This program)
2024 National Qualifier – MS (This program)

Onomastico* by Jonathan Mendoza

You ask me for my name,
and I say, "It's pronounced *Mendoza*,"

I'm sorry. I did not mean to confuse you.

I, too, would like to proudly bestow a heritage,
except I do not know what home
I'd tell my children to go to.
I speak English, and my Abuelo's cane shakes.
I speak Spanish, and an Aztec priest
cradles smallpox with his lungs,
I *say* "Nahuatl," and a Wixarika mother
asks for her daughter back. When I say "home,"
to whose mother am I referring?
Which war am I praying to flee?

Ask me of my name, and I will tell you
of the first men who brought it here,
how they'd unleash dogs onto the children
and clothe entire villages in flames.
Ask me of my name, I'll tell you I only have it
because a Spaniard stamped it
into a Caxcane woman with his teeth.

I'm sorry, I did not mean to bring
my blood into the room.
I, too, would like to state my presence

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and not hawk up a genocide.

I would have known my indigenous parts first,
but I searched for my kin in a schoolbook,
and learned only of them as the European's casualty,
in that I asked for a history
and was handed a cup of blood. I'm sorry,

I reached back across the border
to find anything that has not already been buried,
but most times, I find America imperialized
an already colonized nation.
Most times, I find colony
stacked atop another colony, repeatedly,
a layered cake of mass graves,

I mean the Spanish
literally built the Mexican capitol
over the Aztec city and broadened it
to swallow the entire lake;
each year the city sinks whole feet
into a cavity of its own making.

Ask me of my name, and I'll say

I do not know how to honor my existence

and the holocaust that caused it

in the same mouth.

Ask me of my name,

"It's pronounced Mendoza,"

but a Wixarika elder

sings and cries

You've survived.

Now dig deeper.

Find me."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jonathan Mendoza
Book: On-Line Transcript
https://www.splitthisrock.org/poetry-database/poem/onomastico
Publisher: Split This Rock.org
Date (Month/Year): October 1, 2019

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier – MS (This program)
2021 National Qualifier – MS (This program)

****Translation: The feast of the saint you are named after***

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What's Genocide? by Carlos Andres Gomez

I asked my students,

"Raise your hand if you've heard of the Holocaust."

in unison, their arms rose up like poisonous gas

then straightened out like an SS infantry

Now raise your hand if you've heard of the Rwandan genocide."

blank stares mixed with curious ignorance

a quivering hand out of the crowd

half-way raised, like a lone survivor

struggling to stand up in Kigali

"Luz, are you sure about that?"

"No."

"That's what I thought."

"Carlos, what's genocide?"

your books leave out Emmett Till and Medgar Evers

call themselves "World History" and don't mention

King Leopold or diamond mines

call themselves "Politics in the Modern World"

and don't mention Apartheid

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"Carlos, what's genocide?"

my students thought Che Guevara was a rapper
from East Harlem
still think my Mumia t-shirt is of Bob Marley
how can literacy not include Phillis Wheatley?

"Carlos, what's genocide?"

"Roselyn, how old was she? ***Cuántos años tuvo tu madre cuando se murió?"*** *[How old was your mother when she died?]*

"My mother had 32 years when she died. ***Ella era bellísima***." *[She was so beautiful]*

. . . what's genocide?

they've moved from sterilizing "Boriqua" women
injecting indigenous sisters with Hepatitis B,
now they just kill mothers with silent poison
stain their loyalty and love into veins and suffocate them

. . . what's genocide?

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Ridwan's father hung himself
in the box because he thought his son
was ashamed of him

. . . what's genocide?

Maureen's mother gave her
skin lightening cream
the day before she started the 6th grade

. . . what's genocide?

she carves straight lines into her
beautiful brown thighs so she can remember
what it feels like to heal

. . . what's genocide?
. . . what's genocide?

"Carlos, what's genocide?"

"Luz, this. . .
this right here. . .
is genocide."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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https://www.rattle.com/product/i27/
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Also Found in

Book: Man Up: Reimagining Modern Manhood, Chpt 8
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AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier – MS (This program)
2021 National Qualifier – MS (This program)
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*** Source for the quote in the introduction***
https://latino.si.edu/exhibitions/presente/latino-identity

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